
3.7 Unit 3, Option E: War and Peace: 20th Century International Relations

Focus

This option concentrates on international diplomacy from the late 19th to the late 20th centuries. It focuses on the need for, and robustness of, alliance systems and the reasons for conflict between states. Students are required to study a range of factors associated with the making of alliances, their significance and impact and the importance of armaments policies as an adjunct or threat to the peaceful resolution of disputes. They also address, and are invited to pass reasoned judgement upon, issues which have provoked disagreement and controversy among historians. A key element of study in this option lies in the evaluation of interpretations related to attempts at international co-operation and the ways and reasons for failure of co-operation and conflict resolution.

Clarification of content for each topic can be found in *Appendix 1*.

Students entered for Option E are required to study ONE topic: E1 or E2.

E1 The World in Crisis, 1879-1941

- The making of the European alliance system and the arms race, 1879-1912.
- Pre-war crises, 1905-1914: the First Moroccan Crisis (the Tangier Crisis), 1905-6; the Second Moroccan Crisis (the Agadir Crisis), 1911; the Balkans, 1908-1913; the June-July crisis of 1914.
- The post-war settlement, 1919-22: the Treaties of Versailles, Trianon, Neuilly and Lausanne.
- Disarmament and rearmament, 1919-1939: the Washington Naval Treaties (1922); the Geneva Disarmament Conference, 1932-33; the arms race of the 1930s.

Associated controversies

- a) Why was the League of Nations not more successful?
- b) Why did armed conflict between the major world powers break out in the years 1937-41?

E2 A World Divided: Superpower Relations, 1944-90

- The post-Stalin thaw and the bid for peaceful coexistence: Khrushchev and the responses of Dulles, Eisenhower and Kennedy.
- The arms race, 1949-1963: nuclear technology; delivery systems; the Cuban missile crisis; the Test Ban Treaty.
- Sino-Soviet relations, 1949-76: alliance to confrontation in Asia and its impact on US policy.
- Détente, 1969-1980: the Strategic Arms Limitation Talks (SALT) and agreements; Helsinki Accords; the impact of economic realities.

Associated controversies

- a) Why did the Cold War between the superpowers emerge in the years to 1953?
- b) Why did the Cold War come to an end in the 1980s?